What makes us so good at remembering epic poems and long-running TV series is that long-term human memory is particularly adapted to retaining stories. As Kendall Haven writes in his 2007 book, *Story Proof: The Science Behind the Startling Power of Story*, 'Human minds … rely on stories and on story architecture as the primary roadmap for understanding, making sense of, remembering, and planning our lives … Lives are like stories because we think in story terms.' Haven references more than 120 academic studies, concluding that 'research overwhelmingly, convincingly, and without opposition provides the evidence' that stories are a highly efficient 'vehicle for communicating factual, conceptual, emotional, and tacit information'.[11]

In contrast, most people find it hard to remember lists by heart, and few people would be interested in watching a TV recitation of India's tax records or annual budget. Mnemonic methods used to memorise lists of items often work by weaving the items into a plot, thereby turning the list into a story.[12] But even with the help of such mnemonic devices, who could remember their country's tax records or budget? The information may be vital – determining what quality of health care, education and welfare services citizens enjoy – but our brains are not adapted to remembering such things. Unlike national poems and myths, which can be stored in our brains, complex national taxation and administration systems have required a unique nonorganic information technology in order to function. This technology is the written document.

TO KILL A LOAN

The written document was invented many times in many places. Some of the earliest examples come from ancient Mesopotamia. A cuneiform clay tablet dated to the twenty-eighth day of the tenth month of the forty-first year of the reign of King Shulgi of Ur (*c*. 2053/4 BCE) recorded the monthly deliveries of sheep and goats. Fifteen sheep were delivered on the second day of the month, 7 sheep on the third day, 11 sheep on the fourth, 219 on the fifth, 47 on the sixth, and so on until 3 sheep were delivered on the twenty-eighth. In total, says the clay tablet, 896 animals were received that month. Remembering all these deliveries was important for the royal administration, to monitor people's obedience and to keep track of available